

IN PROFILE

Francesco Florimo

During his college days, Bellini became close to fellow student Francesco Florimo (1800–1888). Their relationship was reinforced by a regular weekly correspondence into which Bellini off-loaded his irritations and projected frequently wild thoughts. Florimo’s great affection for his friend fed his imagination in later years, coloring the biography that he wrote of Bellini in the early 1880s. He burned many letters written while Bellini had one of several affairs with married women, and gave others away, choosing to invent substitute letters in his biography. Florimo spun the myth of Bellini as a Romantic hero—a sensitive, melancholy artist, dead before his time, like Mozart or Byron.

Vincenzo Bellini was born in Catania, Sicily, on November 3, 1801. In the summer of that year, his island home had been attacked by Tunisian pirates eager to capture slaves for the lucrative market in north Africa—an event that sparked a three-year war.

The theme of sea battles with pirates was to reemerge in Bellini’s life many years later in the form of one of his earliest works, *Il pirata*. Also among his formative experiences were the Sicilian and Neapolitan folk songs and theater tunes that he had heard as a boy.

Bellini’s childhood, like much of his short life, was dressed in myth by early biographers (see [box](#)), who portrayed the boy as a doomed genius: “blond as the cornfields, sweet as the angels,” in one account. Bellini was the eldest of seven children; his father and grandfather were musicians. He wrote his first piece of music at the age of six and became his grandfather’s musical apprentice soon after. In 1819, he won a scholarship to the Royal College of Music in Naples, where he honed his skills as a composer for the voice.